

As the 48-hour deadline began to wear thin, trust Dhanraj Pillai to come bursting through the melee and turning a situation around with no more than a flash of his optimism. Kalmadi, in a battle for sporting turf, had called him the previous evening and asked, "Kuch kar sakta hai?" With Pillai at the meeting, everything was, a player

**PRABHJOT SINGH AND SHIVENDRA SINGH CELEBRATE; THE PUNE PRESS CONFERENCE (BOTTOM RIGHT)**

against Sahara weeks after being instituted, was told that the sponsors would "go through past accounts and amicably decide about this amount". Abhijit Sarkar, head of Sahara India corporate communications, said, "We are not doubting the office bearers of the federation but we need transparency. He shouldn't get unsettled by this." Rather than merely unsettled, he in recent months has been totally shaken. The slowness of their opera-

a non-weepee environment was far from impossible, "People raise funding for boxing, shooting and badminton which are not mass-based sports like hockey." In any case from now a visitor is going to knock on the door of every one who has promised donor money for hockey: it will be Pillai in his India shirt, following through on their word.

On the evening the crisis ended, Halappa sounded like a teenager over the telephone. Even though he was



## Promises to Keep

- Incentive payments due within a week
- A graded system of payments in place before the World Cup
- Newly elected officials to fast track all terms

YUSUF KHAN



## Kalmadi's Many Moves

Under pressure from the Sports Ministry to rid Indian hockey of constant bad news, Kalmadi was the man behind the creation of Hockey India (HI). Problems over state-wise affiliation have led to the ministry laying down strict laws for HI elections due on February 7. His rivals in hockey now are Punjab's Sukhbir Badal and Bengal's J.B. Roy.



KALMADI

said, "easier". Because the man asking them to believe Kalmadi's promises (see box) was one who had always scrapped with everything official: whether in a suit or on paper.

Hours after the players spoke of resuming training in Pune, (and Sharma even referred to "happiness"), two demand drafts totalling Rs 1 crore were given from Sahara to HI President A.K. Mattoo in Delhi, as a "suspense account". HI, which had gone to court

since formation, staggering over elections and now the crisis that almost led to Indian hockey imploding.

When HI said it had no money in the bank, the players didn't believe a word and in a reaction that was half emotional outburst, half publicity-stunt, a flood of funding came from state governments, corporates and movie stars.

Former India stalwart Viren Rasquinha, now CEO of Olympic Gold Quest, said funding for hockey even in

talking about the World Cup which suddenly rose on the horizon like a giant target. "It's high time we have to perform," he said. Is that pressure, then? More pressure? Halappa laughed, "No, no pressure. We have always wanted to do well in the World Cup. This was different."

For those five days of difference to echo like a resonant thunderclap, Indian hockey's antiquated and feudalistic rule book must now be re-written. ■